administration called for “speedy withdrawal” by both Vietnam (from Cambodia) and China (from Vietnam).[217] A chagrined Brzezinski noted to Carter that the invasions had created “new uncertainties” in all legs of the China-Soviet-US triangle.[218]

Desai, in turn, lamented to Carter that the developments in Southeast Asia complicated Sino-Indian rapprochement, put a dent in US-Soviet détente, and created the impression in India that Washington knew about—or had looked the other way from—the Chinese invasion. From his letter, it was clear that Soviet premier Alexei Kosygin, who had visited India in March, had propagated the view that Carter had actively encouraged the Chinese step. In his letter, Desai praised Moscow for not jumping into the fray militarily, but he also noted its (unsuccessful) pressure on India to recognize the Vietnamese-backed regime in Cambodia. When it came to the Chinese invasion, however, Desai laid out to Carter the most crucial question for many Indians—and not just for critics of his approach to China: “Can we be confident that China will not exercise, now and more so later, the same right of punitive actions on some other neighbours? India, as you know, is one of them.”[219]

Brzezinski worried that the Chinese attack had “discredited” Vajpayee’s visit domestically. It heightened Indians’ concerns about Sino-US normalization, and increased their support for the Soviet partnership. And it was one more complication for US-India relations at a time when Delhi was already worried that developments in Afghanistan and the Middle East would result in an American buildup in the Indian Ocean and another tilt toward Pakistan.[220]

When Vajpayee subsequently met Carter in Washington, the American president said that he was “disconcerted” that the Vietnam episode had been a “wet blanket” on the Indian foreign minister’s “important trip” to China. He hoped the “lack of Chinese sensitivity” did not cause lasting damage to the prospects for Sino-Indian relations. Deng, the president said, was “very enthusiastic” about better relations. Vajpayee outlined the domestic criticism he was facing and the offense that the 1962 reference had caused. But, he said his government had “not lost hope.”[221]

Two months later, Desai and Vajpayee would lose their jobs, and, shortly after, the JP would lose power. The Carter administration’s India attention meanwhile would give way to a focus on Afghanistan and Pakistan. In